

METROPOLITAN POLICE DEPARTMENT

HOMICIDE INVESTIGATION REPORT

Case Number:	HOM-2024-11-22-0347
Incident Type:	Homicide - Blunt Force Trauma
Date/Time Reported:	November 22, 2024, 06:15 hours
Date/Time of Incident:	November 22, 2024, approx. 02:47-03:00 hours
Location:	Alley behind 1500 block Commerce Street
Victim:	CONFIDENTIAL, 34-year-old Male
Primary Officer:	Officer J. Davidson (#1523)
Assisting Officer:	Officer M. Liu (#2891)
Lead Detective:	Detective Karen Rodriguez, Homicide Division
Status:	Suspect in custody, charges pending

INCIDENT SUMMARY

On November 22, 2024, at approximately 06:15 hours, patrol units responded to a report of an injured person in an alleyway behind the 1500 block of Commerce Street. Upon arrival, officers discovered an adult male with severe head trauma who was obviously deceased. The scene was secured as a homicide investigation. Through investigation including witness statements, video surveillance, physical evidence, and forensic analysis, a suspect was identified and taken into custody. The investigation remains ongoing.

INITIAL RESPONSE

Dispatch and Scene Arrival

At 06:15 hours, Communications Division received a 911 call from a citizen reporting what appeared to be an injured or deceased person in an alley. The reporting party, later identified as James Morrison, stated he was walking to his vehicle when he observed what looked like a body lying in the

alley with a large amount of blood visible.

Officers Davidson (#1523) and Liu (#2891) were dispatched and arrived on scene at 06:18 hours. Officers approached the alley and immediately observed an adult male lying on his back with obvious severe head injuries and a large pool of blood surrounding the head and upper body. The individual was obviously deceased with no signs of life. Officers immediately secured the scene, established a perimeter, and requested emergency medical services, homicide detectives, and crime scene investigators.

Initial Scene Assessment

EMS arrived at 06:22 hours and confirmed death at the scene without attempting resuscitation due to injuries obviously incompatible with life. Sergeant Thompson arrived at 06:25 hours and assumed supervisory responsibility. Homicide Detective Rodriguez arrived at 06:45 hours and assumed primary investigative responsibility. Crime Scene Investigation Unit arrived at 06:52 hours and began documentation and evidence collection.

CRIME SCENE INVESTIGATION

Scene Description

The crime scene is located in an alleyway running north-south between two commercial buildings in a mixed commercial and residential district. The alley measures approximately 12 feet in width and provides access to rear entrances and dumpsters for adjacent businesses. The scene is approximately 30 feet from the north entrance of the alley (Commerce Street side). Lighting in the alley is limited, with a single overhead light approximately 50 feet south of the scene.

The victim was positioned lying supine (on his back) with his head toward the west wall of the alley. A massive pool of blood surrounded the head measuring approximately 4 feet in diameter. Blood spatter patterns were documented on the west wall (brick) extending approximately 6 feet vertically and 8 feet horizontally from the body position.

Physical Evidence Documentation

Crime scene investigators documented the scene through photographs, videography, measurements, and sketches. The following physical evidence was identified, documented, and collected:

Item #1 - Metal Pipe: A metal pipe was located approximately 15 feet south of the victim's body, near a green dumpster on the east side of the alley. The pipe measures 24 inches in length, 2 inches in diameter, and appears to be galvanized steel. One end of the pipe exhibits visible biological material consistent with blood and tissue. The pipe was photographed in situ, marked with evidence tag #1, collected using proper technique to preserve biological evidence, and packaged for transport to the crime laboratory.

Item #2 - Cellular Phone: A cellular phone was located beneath the victim's body during body removal. The phone is an iPhone in a black case with screen damage. The phone was seized for analysis of call records, text messages, and other data.

Item #3 - Wallet: The victim's wallet was located in his right rear pants pocket. The wallet contained driver's license, credit cards, and \$43 cash. No evidence of robbery is apparent.

Item #4 - Cigarette Butts: Three cigarette butts were collected from the area, two near the body and one near the dumpster. These were packaged separately for potential DNA analysis.

Item #5 - Blood Samples: Blood swabs were collected from various locations including the metal pipe, wall spatter, and pooled blood for comparison with victim and suspect samples.

Blood Pattern Analysis

Blood pattern analyst T. Morrison documented extensive spatter patterns consistent with multiple high-force impacts to the head. Impact spatter patterns on the brick wall demonstrate characteristics of blunt force trauma with velocity consistent with a weapon being swung. Cast-off patterns indicate the weapon was swung repeatedly, with blood being cast off during the back-swing motion. The pattern analysis supports at least 5-7 separate impacts. No blood trail leading to or from the scene suggests the assault occurred at the location where the body was found.

WITNESS STATEMENTS

Discovering Witness - James Morrison

Mr. James Morrison (DOB 07/15/1989, 2847 Oak Street) provided the following statement: He left his apartment at approximately 06:10 hours to walk to his vehicle, which was parked on Commerce Street. As he approached his vehicle, he noticed what appeared to be a person lying in the alley. He approached closer and observed obvious injuries and blood. He immediately called 911 without entering the alley or disturbing the scene. He stated he did not witness the assault and did not see any other individuals in the area. He reported no knowledge of the victim and had not heard any disturbances during the night.

Canvass Results

A neighborhood canvass was conducted of all residences and businesses within a three-block radius. Most residents reported being asleep during the time frame and heard nothing unusual. One resident, Ms. Carol Chen (Apt 2B, 1502 Commerce Street), reported hearing what sounded like raised voices coming from the alley area at approximately 02:45-03:00 hours but did not investigate or call police. She could not provide specific details about the voices or number of people involved.

VIDEO SURVEILLANCE EVIDENCE

Security Camera Footage - Critical Evidence

Investigators identified multiple businesses in the area equipped with external security cameras. Video footage from Lee's Market (1498 Commerce Street) proved critical to the investigation. The camera is positioned above the store entrance with a field of view that includes the north entrance of the alley where the crime occurred.

Video Timeline Analysis: At 02:47:33 hours, two individuals are observed entering the alley together. Both individuals are males, walking side by side in what appears to be conversation. One individual is wearing a dark hoodie and jeans (later identified as the victim). The second individual is wearing a distinctive red and white jacket, dark pants, and a baseball cap (later identified as the suspect).

At 02:55:18 hours (approximately 8 minutes later), one individual exits the alley at a rapid walking pace, appearing to carry a cylindrical object approximately 2 feet in length. The individual is wearing the red and white jacket and cap. The individual's face is partially obscured by the cap, but distinctive features including body build, gait, and clothing are clearly visible. The individual turns west on Commerce Street and moves out of camera view.

No other individuals are observed entering or exiting the alley during the relevant time frame. The victim is never observed exiting the alley, consistent with the location where his body was discovered.

Additional Video Evidence

Subsequent investigation identified additional cameras along the suspect's apparent route of departure. Video from a bank ATM camera two blocks west captured the same distinctive red and white jacket at 03:02 hours. Video from a residential doorbell camera three blocks away captured the suspect entering a vehicle matching the description of the suspect's registered vehicle at 03:15 hours. This video footage provided crucial evidence linking the suspect to the scene and establishing timeline.

INVESTIGATIVE FINDINGS

Victim Identification and Background

The victim was identified through driver's license and confirmed via fingerprint comparison. Background investigation revealed the victim was employed as a construction supervisor, lived with a roommate, and had no significant criminal history. The victim's cellular phone records were obtained through search warrant and revealed extensive text message communication with an individual later identified as the suspect in the hours preceding the homicide.

Text Message Evidence

Analysis of the victim's phone revealed text messages arranging to meet at approximately 02:30 hours at the alley location. The messages indicated tension regarding money owed. Specific messages recovered include: (02:17 hrs) Suspect: 'Meet me at the usual spot. Time to settle this.' (02:23 hrs) Victim: 'I told you I'll get you the money.' (02:31 hrs) Suspect: 'I'm here. Where you at?' The final message from the victim's phone was at 02:42 hours stating 'Be there in 5.'

Suspect Identification

Through analysis of the victim's phone contacts and comparison with video surveillance, a suspect was identified. The suspect's vehicle was identified through DMV records and located at his residence. A search warrant was obtained for the suspect's residence and vehicle approximately 36 hours after the homicide.

SUSPECT APPREHENSION AND EVIDENCE

Search Warrant Execution

On November 23, 2024, at 18:30 hours, a search warrant was executed at the suspect's residence. The suspect was taken into custody without incident. The following evidence was seized: the red and white jacket visible in surveillance video (found in suspect's closet, showing visible blood staining on sleeves and front), dark pants with blood staining, baseball cap, athletic shoes with apparent blood on soles, and the suspect's vehicle showing blood smears on door handle.

Forensic Evidence Results

Preliminary field testing of stains on the jacket produced positive results for blood. The jacket and other clothing items were submitted to the crime laboratory for DNA analysis. Initial results confirmed the presence of blood matching the victim's DNA profile on the jacket sleeves and front panel. The metal pipe recovered from the scene tested positive for blood matching the victim's DNA and contained fingerprints matching the suspect.

Suspect Interview

The suspect was interviewed after being advised of Miranda rights. Initially, the suspect denied any involvement and claimed he was home asleep during the time of the incident. When confronted with video evidence showing him entering the alley with the victim and exiting alone, the suspect altered his statement, claiming they met briefly to talk but parted ways peacefully. When informed of the forensic evidence including blood on his clothing, the suspect invoked his right to counsel and declined further questioning.

CONCLUSIONS

Based on the comprehensive investigation including crime scene evidence, video surveillance, forensic analysis, and cellular phone records, there is probable cause to believe that the suspect is responsible for the homicide of the victim. The evidence establishes that the suspect and victim met at the alley location in the early morning hours of November 22, 2024, apparently to resolve a dispute over money owed. The suspect assaulted the victim with a metal pipe, causing fatal head injuries, and fled the scene. The suspect was arrested and charged with Murder in the First Degree.

The investigation is ongoing. Additional forensic results are pending. The case has been referred to the District Attorney's Office for prosecution.

Detective Karen Rodriguez, Homicide Division

Reviewed and Approved: Lieutenant James Foster, Homicide Division Commander

Date: November 24, 2024